

and body text plus a category. Twitter changed all of that by putting it all in one small box.

Twitter's own API, which allowed third parties to connect to Twitter in a wide variety of ways, was equally significant – and equally underappreciated. Dorsey envisioned Twitter as a technology, not a product. Apps, Twitter clients, schedulers, dashboards – everything prospered thanks to an explicitly open architecture. Twitter of the early days wasn't a walled garden but rather an open square with gates wide open. It was that openness that made Twitter the connective tissue of the internet for almost ten years. It was, moreover, exactly that openness that Dorsey mourned when the company decided to lock those gates. He wasn't merely nostalgic about that period. As Dorsey himself noted several times, Twitter never should have been a traditional tech company but rather should have been designed like a protocol, much like emails or podcasting. Something he built as infrastructure and saw being transformed into a product frustrated him immensely – and that frustration defined everything that he did after.

Block: Finance as open infrastructure

At the time when Dorsey created Square in 2009, there really weren't any mobile card readers to speak of. Small businesses, food truck owners, market stall holders, and freelancers alike were shut out of card transactions due to the high bar set by having to get a merchant account, a card terminal at the point of sale, and a banking account. Square's original device was a small, white box that connected via a headphone jack and came with no upfront costs at all. As always, the limitation was that instead of making an entire payment solution, he made something minimalist. Accept a card transaction.

From that one idea, the company that one day became Block evolved

into a whole ecosystem of finance – including Cash App, Afterpay, merchant loans, but design principles were consistent throughout them all. Each product aimed to strip away an institutional level of friction where you needed money to access money. With Cash App, you could transfer funds without having to go through a bank. Likewise, the Bitcoin offering on Cash App was a philosophy rather than something chasing trends; Dorsey has consistently referred to Bitcoin as being the closest financial system to becoming truly decentralized, borderless, and permissionless – controlled by no single party. He has said that watching Cash App integrate Bitcoin's Lightning Network was one of the proudest moments of his career.

Block's overall bet on Bitcoin infrastructure, however, goes much deeper. With Spiral, Block developed open-source technology initiatives for Bitcoin as a means of economic empowerment. Through Proto, the firm has created a range of Bitcoin mining technologies meant to democratize the process of mining. The pattern is the same one that ran through Twitter's early API years: build the open layer, fund the open layer, and let others build on top.

With Block, Dorsey tried to do with money what he had initially done with speech, reduce it to a primitive that anyone can access without asking a corporation for permission.

Bitchat: Communication without the internet

Fast forward to July 2025, Dorsey posted on X that he was spending his weekend getting familiar with topics like Bluetooth mesh networking, relay models, store-and-forward messaging, and message encryption. A few days later, Bitchat came into existence. The very first version of the app had been built in a single weekend, which could either be considered an impressive feat of Dorsey's technical

knowledge and capabilities or just another brand-appropriate move by him, probably both.

Bitchat is a messaging app that does not require you to connect to the internet or even use a server of any kind. It uses a two-level transportation infrastructure, Bluetooth Low Energy for local offline mesh communication, where messages hop between nearby devices to reach their destination, and the Nostr protocol for internet-based global messaging when connectivity is available. No registration, no identity, and no mediator whatsoever. Dorsey open-sourced the code from day one.

The true test of just how much Bitchat was worth came quickly. By early 2026, Apple had pulled it from China's App Store at the direct request of the Cyberspace Administration of China. The app had spread rapidly in Uganda ahead of elections, with downloads spiking by tens of thousands in a single week amid fears of an internet shutdown. Usage increased threefold in Iran during times of communications limitations due to protests. An app that had been built in a single weekend by an individual became critical infrastructure for citizens in states where internet access was treated as a lever that can be pulled.

Dorsey called it his personal experiment. Creating a censorship-resistant, server-less communication system and then making the source code free is a very specific experiment. It was the same strategy he has adopted each time, simplify the concept down to its basic components, make it open, and then let it go. Three products. One fingerprint across all three of them. Keep it simple, keep it open, and make it universal. Steve Jobs built things people needed. Gates built things everyone could afford to use. Dorsey keeps building things that do not need him, or anyone else, to keep running. That might be the most radical design philosophy of all. **d**